

AGRI_EMPOWER TRAINING SERIES

Yam Mastery: Foundation Level (Curriculum Manual)

Program Overview

The Foundation Level is designed to establish the core practical skills required to cultivate yam successfully at a small-to-medium scale. The focus is on traditional best practices, manual efficiency, and fundamental crop safety.

Module 1: Production and Management

- **Site Selection:** Identifying fertile "indicators" like thick vegetation. Avoiding waterlogged or rocky soils.
- **Manual Land Clearing:** Techniques for clearing without stripping topsoil nutrients. Importance of stump removal for tuber shape.
- **Mound Formation (Heaps):** Creating mounds approximately 60-75cm high. Spacing heaps 1 meter apart for optimal root spread.
- **Planting Technique:** Proper "eye-up" orientation of the seed sett. Depth control (approx. 10cm) to prevent sun-scorch or rot.

Module 2: Pest, Disease, and Soil Health

- **Soil Texture Basics:** The "Squeeze Test" to identify Sandy Loam.
- **Manual Weeding:** Timing weeding within the first 3-8 weeks to eliminate nutrient competition.
- **Mulching:** Using dry biomass to cap heaps, protecting the seed sett from high soil temperatures.

- **Basic Identification:** Recognizing yam beetles (tuber holes) and termites (surface damage).

Module 3: Post-Harvest and Storage

- **Signs of Maturity:** Monitoring leaf senescence (yellowing) and vine drying.
- **Damage Prevention:** Using wooden tools to avoid skin abrasions that lead to fungal infection.
- **The Traditional Barn:** Building vertical racks in shaded, well-ventilated areas to prevent weight loss and rot.

Module 4: Processing and Value Addition

- **Sun-Drying:** Blanching (parboiling) techniques for creating white chips.
- **Hygiene Standards:** Keeping processing areas free of contaminants to ensure shelf stability.
- **Basic Milling:** Converting dried chips into flour for domestic use.

Module 5: Agribusiness and Markets

- **Simple Bookkeeping:** Tracking seed costs and labor hours in a farm diary.
- **Market Awareness:** Understanding price cycles between harvest (low price) and the lean season (high price).
- **Customer Relations:** Standards for sorting and grading yams by size for local sales.

Competency Check

A Foundation-level trainee must demonstrate the ability to: (1) Correctly orient a seed sett in a mound, (2) Identify three signs of yam maturity, and (3) Explain why mulching is critical for newly planted yams.